



The Science of Shopping

My mission one day was a drastically discounted coffeemaker, which I had spotted in the Sunday sales ad. The layout of the store confused me as soon as I set foot in the door. The aisles went in a somewhat circular pattern, racks on either side soon obliterating any sign of either entrance or exit. Disoriented, I ended up in the women's lingerie section where I'd spotted a prominent "70% off" sign. Despite my best intentions, I left the store with two bags of clearance merchandise, along with the coffeemaker I'd come for.

Some store designers deliberately create spaces that will be confusing so that customers become disoriented, losing control of their ability to make good purchasing decisions, which results in impulse buys. This is called "The Gruen Transfer," a psychological phenomenon named after Victor Gruen, an Austrian-born architect who designed one of the earliest shopping malls in America. The classic signs that someone is experiencing the Gruen Transfer are a dropped jaw, slightly glazed eyes, and a hazy, confused feeling. By the time they reach this point, many people will have slowed down their walking pace. Ironically, Gruen himself disliked the level of manipulation necessary to trigger this mental state, and his intention was to create shopping malls that didn't confuse consumers into buying things they